

Word family: **tree / trees / treelike / tree-lined / treehouse**

Base word: tree

Plural: trees

Related forms / useful extensions: treelike, tree-lined, treehouse

Useful expressions / extensions: family tree, decision tree, tree diagram, tree structure, branch of a tree

Part of speech: mainly noun (名詞) / compound-forming noun (構成複合詞)

Your sentence:

> “To me she is a bit like an old **tree**: she does not move much, but she gives other people shade, stability, and comfort.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **tree** is used literally as a plant, but the sentence uses it in a **metaphorical comparison**.

Your grandmother is compared to an old tree because an old tree can suggest:

- * stability
- * endurance
- * shelter
- * calm presence
- * protection
- * long life

So the word **tree** itself still keeps its ordinary meaning, while the sentence gives it symbolic force through metaphor.

繁體中文： **有木質樹幹、枝幹和樹葉的多年生大型植物；在這裡被用作比喻，象徵穩定、長久、庇護和令人安心的存在**

中文翻譯：

> “To me she is a bit like an old tree...”

「對我來說，她有點像一棵**老樹**.....」

Here:

tree = 樹；在比喻中令人聯想到穩定、長久和庇護

1. **tree = large woody plant (樹) — 樹木；樹**

This is the core literal meaning.

Practice 1 — Original

> “She is a bit like an old **tree**.”

「她有點像一棵**老樹**。」

Practice 2

> “There is a large **tree** outside the house.”

「房子外面有一棵大**樹**。」

Practice 3

> “The children sat under the **tree**.”

「孩子們坐在**樹下**。」

tree = 有木質主幹、枝條和樹葉，通常可以生長很多年的大型植物

2. **tree** = source of shade/shelter (遮蔭 / 庇護來源) — 樹；遮蔭物

This is not a separate lexical meaning of **tree**, but it is an important contextual extension in your sentence.

Practice 4

> “We sat under a **tree** for shade.”

「我們坐在一棵**樹下乘涼**。」

Practice 5

> “The old **tree** sheltered them from the sun.”

「那棵老**樹**替他們**遮擋陽光**。」

tree = 在實際環境中提供遮蔭、庇護和休息空間的樹木

This physical property supports your passage's metaphorical meaning.

3. **tree** = symbol of strength/stability/growth (比喻 / 象徵) — 穩定、成長或生命的象徵

This is a figurative symbolic use rather than a different dictionary sense.

Practice 6

> “The **tree** became a symbol of strength and endurance.”

「那棵**樹**成為力量和堅韌的象徵。」

Practice 7

> “In the story, the old **tree** represents stability.”

「在故事中，那棵老**樹**象徵穩定。」

tree = 在文學或比喻中常用來象徵生命、成長、穩定、根基或長久

This is exactly the mechanism used in your passage.

4. **family tree** (家譜) — 家族樹；家譜

A very common figurative compound.

Practice 8

> “She drew a **family tree**.”

「她畫了一個**家譜 / 家族樹**。」

Practice 9

> “The website helped him build his **family tree**.”

「那個網站幫助他建立自己的**家譜**。」

family tree = 用樹狀結構表示家族成員和世代關係的圖表

The metaphor comes from:

* trunk

* branches

* descendants

5. **decision tree (決策樹) — 決策樹**

A common technical/business/data term.

Practice 10

> “The team used a **decision tree** to compare the options.”

「團隊使用**決策樹**比較不同選項。」

Practice 11

> “A **decision tree** can show possible outcomes.”

「**決策樹**可以顯示不同可能結果。」

****decision tree = 用分支結構表示不同選擇及其可能結果的圖表 / 模型****

6. **tree diagram (樹狀圖) — 樹狀圖**

Practice 12

> “The information is shown in a **tree diagram**.”

「資料以**樹狀圖**顯示。」

Practice 13

> “Use a **tree diagram** to organize the categories.”

「使用**樹狀圖**整理不同類別。」

****tree diagram = 由主幹和分支形式展示層級 / 分類關係的圖表****

7. **tree structure (樹狀結構) — 樹狀結構；階層結構**

A very useful computing/information-structure sense.

Practice 14

> “The folders are organized in a **tree structure**.”

「資料夾以**樹狀階層結構**排列。」

Practice 15

> “The website uses a **tree structure** for navigation.”

「這個網站以**樹狀結構**安排導覽。」

tree structure = 由一個起點向下分支形成多層級關係的結構

Common in:

- * computing
- * file systems
- * databases
- * organizational charts

8. **tree** — computing/data structure (資料結構) — 樹；樹狀資料結構

A genuine technical lexical use.

Practice 16

> “The program stores the data in a **tree**.”

「程式把資料儲存在一個**樹狀資料結構**中。」

Practice 17

> “Each node in the **tree** may have several children.”

「這個**樹狀結構**中的每個節點可以有多個子節點。」

tree = 在電腦科學中，以節點和分支構成的階層式資料結構

This is distinct enough to count as a technical meaning.

9. **branch of a tree** (分支) — 樹枝；分支

This belongs to the tree metaphor family.

Practice 18

> “The bird landed on a **branch of the tree**.”

「那隻鳥停在**樹枝**上。」

Practice 19

> “Each branch of the decision **tree** represents a choice.”

「決策**樹**的每個分支代表一個選擇。」

tree imagery = 主幹和分支常被借用來表示層級、分類、發展或選擇

10. **tree-lined** = lined with trees (兩旁有樹的) — 林蔭的 ; 兩旁植樹的

A useful adjective compound.

Practice 20

> “They walked along a **tree-lined** street.”

「他們沿著一條**林蔭街道 / 兩旁種滿樹的街道**散步。」

Practice 21

> “The neighbourhood has several **tree-lined** roads.”

「這個社區有幾條**兩旁植滿樹木的道路**。」

tree-lined = 道路、街道等兩旁種有一排 / 多排樹木的

11. **treelike** = resembling a tree (像樹的) — 樹狀的 ; 像樹的

Practice 22

> “The coral has a **treelike** shape.”

「這種珊瑚呈現**樹狀外形**。」

Practice 23

> “The network forms a **treelike** pattern.”

「這個網絡形成一種**樹狀模式**。」

treelike = 在外形或結構上像樹一樣有主體和分支

12. **treehouse** = house/platform built in a tree (樹屋) — 樹屋

Practice 24

> “The children built a **treehouse**.”

「孩子們建了一間**樹屋**。」

Practice 25

> “They spent the afternoon in the **treehouse**.”

「他們整個下午都待在**樹屋**裡。」

treehouse = 建在樹上或由樹支撐的小屋 / 平台

13. **tree line / treeline** (樹線) — 林木線；樹木生長界線

A useful geography/ecology term.

Practice 26

> “Few trees grow above the **tree line**.”

「在**林木線**以上很少有樹木生長。」

Practice 27

> “The trail climbs beyond the **treeline**.”

「山徑延伸到**樹木生長界線**以上。」

tree line = 因氣候或海拔條件限制，樹木能正常生長的最高 / 最遠界線

14. **tree ring (年輪) — 樹木年輪**

Practice 28

> “Scientists study **tree rings** to estimate age.”

「科學家研究**樹木年輪**來估計樹齡。」

Practice 29

> “Each **tree ring** records part of the tree’s growth history.”

「每一圈**年輪**都記錄了樹木部分的生長歷史。」

tree ring = 樹幹橫切面上反映年度生長的環狀紋理

This fits especially well with the “old tree” imagery in your passage.

15. **rooted tree / branching tree metaphor (根基 / 分支比喻) — 有根基、分支的結構**

This is not a separate lexical meaning but an important metaphorical extension.

Practice 30

> “The organization grew like a **tree**, with many branches.”

「這個組織像一棵**樹**一樣發展出許多分支。」

Practice 31

> “Her family history is represented as a **tree** with deep roots.”

「她的家族歷史被畫成一棵有深根的**樹**。」

tree metaphor = 常用「根、主幹、分支」來表示來源、穩定、發展和關係網絡

Important distinction: **tree vs plant**

plant

is the broad category.

It includes:

- * trees
- * flowers
- * grasses
- * shrubs

****tree****

usually means a larger woody plant with a trunk.

So:

> every tree is a plant

but:

> not every plant is a tree.

Important distinction: ****tree vs bush/shrub****

****tree****

usually has:

- * one main woody trunk
- * greater height

****bush/shrub****

usually has:

- * several stems from near ground level
- * shorter growth

The biological distinction can vary, but this is the useful everyday contrast.

Important distinction: ****tree vs wood****

tree

= the living plant.

wood

= the hard material making up its trunk and branches.

> “The tree is old.”

= 這棵樹很老。

> “The table is made of wood.”

= 桌子由木材製成。

Important distinction: **tree vs forest**

tree

= one individual plant.

forest

= a large area containing many trees and other vegetation.

So:

> tree = 單棵樹

> forest = 森林

Important distinction: **tree vs branch**

tree

= whole organism/structure.

branch

= one division extending from the trunk.

This relationship is what makes **tree** useful metaphorically for hierarchical systems.

Important distinction: **tree** — literal vs **tree** — data structure

Literal:

> “The bird is in the tree.”

= 鳥在樹上。

Computing:

> “The data is stored in a tree.”

= 資料存放在樹狀資料結構中。

The technical sense borrows the same visual structure:

> root → branches → nodes.

Important distinction: **tree** vs **tree diagram**

tree

in computing/mathematics can be the actual abstract structure.

tree diagram

is a visual representation of branching possibilities or relationships.

So the diagram shows the tree structure, but the abstract structure itself may also simply be called a **tree**.

Important distinction: **old tree** — literal vs **symbolic**

In your sentence:

> “She is a bit like an old tree.”

old tree is literally:

> 一棵生長了很多年的樹

But the comparison suggests symbolic qualities such as:

- * endurance
- * stability
- * rootedness
- * shelter
- * longevity

Those symbolic qualities come from the metaphorical context, not from a separate dictionary meaning of **tree** itself.

Important distinction: tree vs family tree

tree

= literal plant.

family tree

= diagram of family relationships.

The compound is not about a physical tree; the tree shape is borrowed to show:

> ancestors → branches → descendants.

Important distinction: tree-lined vs wooded

tree-lined

= trees arranged along the sides of a road/path.

wooded

= an area covered with many trees.

> tree-lined street

> = 林蔭街道

> wooded hillside

> = 長滿樹木的山坡

Family-extension note

Following the reference curation style, these are especially useful members and constructions of the **tree** family:

- * **tree** — literal plant = 樹 / 樹木
- * **tree** — symbolic/metaphorical = 穩定、成長、生命、庇護等象徵
- * **family tree** = 家譜 / 家族樹
- * **decision tree** = 決策樹
- * **tree diagram** = 樹狀圖
- * **tree structure** = 樹狀 / 階層結構
- * **tree** — computing = 樹狀資料結構
- * **tree-lined** = 林蔭的 / 兩旁植樹的
- * **treelike** = 樹狀的 / 像樹的
- * **treehouse** = 樹屋
- * **tree line / treeline** = 林木線
- * **tree ring** = 年輪

This is a relatively **moderate polysemy case**. The strongest genuinely separate learner-relevant sense is:

- > **literal biological tree**
- > versus
- > **technical branching structure**

while many other uses are metaphorical compounds built from the same visual idea of a trunk with branches. That matches the SOP's instruction to keep useful extensions but avoid artificially splitting one underlying concept.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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tree — literal plant	有木質主幹和枝條、通常能生長多年的大型植物
tree — shade/shelter context	能提供遮蔭、庇護或休息空間的樹木
tree — symbolic use	在比喻 / 文學中象徵生命、成長、穩定、根基或長久
family tree	用樹狀結構表示家族世代和親屬關係的圖表
decision tree	用分支結構表示選擇和可能結果的圖表 / 模型
tree diagram	用主幹和分支方式展示層級、分類或可能性的圖表
tree structure	由一個起點向下分支形成多層級關係的結構
tree — computing	由節點和分支構成的階層式資料結構

tree-lined	道路 / 街道兩旁排列種有樹木的	
treelike	外形或結構像樹一樣具有主體和分支的	
treehouse	建在樹上或由樹支撐的小屋 / 平台	
tree line	因氣候、海拔等限制而形成的樹木正常生長界線	
tree ring	樹幹橫切面上反映年度生長的環狀紋理	

For your original sentence

> “To me she is a bit like an old ****tree****: she does not move much, but she gives other people shade, stability, and comfort.”

The exact meaning is:

****tree = 有木質主幹、枝條和樹葉的多年生大型植物****

But the sentence uses that literal image ****metaphorically****.

Therefore:

> ****like an old tree****

= ****「像一棵老樹一樣，給人穩定、庇護、安心和長久存在的感覺」****

The important point is that we should ****not invent a separate lexical meaning****:

> tree = wise elderly person ❌

That meaning comes from the metaphorical comparison created by the whole sentence.

So this is a very good example of the Golden Manual principle:

****the word keeps its core meaning, while the surrounding context creates the figurative interpretation.****